Gyanshauryam, International Scientific Refereed Research Journal
© 2022 GISRRJ | Volume 5 | Issue 3 | ISSN : 2582-0095

A Cross-Market Strategy Framework for Brand Architecture in Legacy FMCG Portfolios

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Artic Info

Publication Issue :
Volume 5, Issue 3
May-June-2022

Article History
Accepted : 01 May 2022
Published : 20 June 2022

Page Number : 186-204

ABSTRACT - Legacy Fast-Moving Consumer Goods (FMCG) portfolios face growing complexity as they navigate fragmented markets, evolving consumer preferences, and intensifying regulatory scrutiny. In this dynamic landscape, an integrated cross-market strategy framework for brand architecture is essential to ensure coherence, operational efficiency, and sustained brand relevance. This proposes a strategic approach to reconfiguring legacy FMCG brand structures across diverse market environments, balancing global consistency with local adaptability. The framework begins by establishing a clear understanding of brand architecture models—branded house, house of brands, and hybrid systems—and how they function within aging, multi-tiered product portfolios. It then introduces market archetyping as a critical tool for segmenting target regions by regulatory intensity, consumer behavior, and market maturity. This enables the development of tailored brand roles and portfolio maps that align with specific business conditions and consumer expectations in each geography. Central to the strategy is the tension between harmonization and differentiation. The framework outlines methods for determining which brand elements—such as core identity, visual codes, and value propositions—should remain globally consistent, and which—such as product names, claims, and packaging—require localized customization. Governance structures, including brand guidelines, digital asset management systems (DAMs), and centralized oversight, are proposed to support cross-market alignment while ensuring agility. Finally, this discusses performance metrics and strategic ROI indicators for brand architecture decisions, such as SKU rationalization, brand equity tracking, and speed-to-market. It also addresses future-proofing through modular systems that accommodate innovation, regulatory change, and acquisition integration. By implementing this cross-market framework, legacy FMCG

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companies can streamline their portfolios, enhance consumer relevance, and increase regulatory resilience—ultimately transforming brand architecture into a lever for sustainable growth across diverse and evolving markets.

Keywords : Cross-market, Strategy framework, Brand architecture, Legacy FMCG portfolios

1. Introduction

In the context of Fast-Moving Consumer Goods (FMCG), brand architecture refers to the structured organization of a company's brand portfolio, including the relationships between corporate, master, sub-, and product brands. It defines how brands are positioned, named, and visually expressed across product categories and markets (Otokiti, 2019; SHARMA *et al.*, 2019). As FMCG firms increasingly operate across borders, brand architecture serves as a strategic framework to manage brand equity, drive marketing efficiency, and deliver consistent consumer experiences. The architecture not only influences how consumers perceive a brand but also dictates internal decision-making regarding resource allocation, product development, and market expansion (Lawal *et al.*, 2014; Amos *et al.*, 2014).

For legacy FMCG portfolios, typically characterized by decades of product evolution, acquisitions, and geographic diversification, brand architecture presents a unique set of challenges (Akinbola and Otokiti, 2012; Otokiti, 2017). Over time, many companies accumulate overlapping sub-brands, region-specific SKUs, and inconsistent positioning strategies. This fragmentation dilutes brand equity, confuses consumers, and increases operational complexity. Additionally, legacy brands often suffer from outdated positioning—where the core brand proposition no longer aligns with contemporary consumer values such as sustainability, wellness, or digital lifestyle integration (Ajonbadi *et al.*, 2015; Otokiti, 2017). These inconsistencies are further compounded by regulatory pressures, especially in emerging and transitional markets like those in Africa, Southeast Asia, or Latin America, where advertising, labeling, and packaging requirements vary significantly (Otokiti, 2017; Otokiti and Akorede, 2018).

In such a landscape, the absence of a coherent brand architecture across markets can lead to inefficiencies and lost opportunities. For example, misaligned packaging systems can inflate costs, while inconsistent brand narratives can erode trust. Similarly, a lack of harmonization hinders the ability to quickly respond to global trends or introduce innovation at scale. Thus, FMCG companies must adopt a cross-market strategy framework that reconciles global consistency with local relevance (Otokiti and Akinbola, 2013; Ajonbadi *et al.*, 2016).

The purpose of a cross-market strategy is threefold: harmonization, growth scalability, and operational efficiency. Harmonization ensures that core brand values and identity are preserved across markets, reinforcing brand equity and trust regardless of geography. It involves aligning visual systems, messaging frameworks, and category roles while leaving room for market-specific customization. Growth scalability enables brands to expand into new markets or product categories with greater speed and lower risk by leveraging consistent branding systems and processes. This is particularly important in digital commerce environments, where consumer touchpoints are increasingly global and borderless. Finally, operational

efficiency is achieved through reduced duplication, streamlined production systems, and integrated marketing workflows. For instance, centralized digital asset management (DAM) and modular packaging templates can cut costs and reduce time-to-market while ensuring compliance with local regulations.

Moreover, a well-structured brand architecture allows legacy FMCG brands to integrate innovation and acquisitions more seamlessly. As many firms acquire niche or regional brands to meet evolving consumer demands, the absence of a unifying architecture can lead to strategic misalignment. A cross-market framework provides clarity on how acquired brands should be positioned—whether as standalone assets or integrated under a master brand umbrella—thus safeguarding coherence and long-term equity (FAGBORE *et al.*, 2020; Nwani *et al.*, 2020).

Ultimately, the introduction of a cross-market brand architecture strategy is not merely a structural exercise; it is a strategic necessity in a volatile global environment. It enables legacy FMCG companies to modernize their brand systems, strengthen consumer relevance, and enhance their ability to operate in diverse and often unpredictable market contexts (Olajide *et al.*, 2020; Akinbola *et al.*, 2020). This explores the components and implementation pathways of such a framework, emphasizing how legacy brands can transform complexity into competitive advantage through disciplined and future-proof brand architecture design.

2. Methodology

This systematic review was conducted following the PRISMA 2020 methodology to synthesize existing literature, strategic models, and empirical case studies relevant to the development of a cross-market strategy framework for brand architecture within legacy fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) portfolios. The objective was to identify the principles, challenges, and enablers of adapting brand architecture across geographies while maintaining core equity, meeting local relevance, and ensuring operational efficiency.

A structured search was carried out across major academic databases including Scopus, Web of Science, Business Source Premier, and Google Scholar, covering publications from 2000 to 2024. Additional grey literature was included, drawing on strategic consultancy reports, brand architecture white papers, global marketing case studies, and annual reports of major FMCG firms. Search terms included combinations of "brand architecture," "cross-market strategy," "FMCG portfolio," "global-local brand management," "masterbrand vs sub-brand," and "legacy brand adaptation." Studies were included if they addressed brand architecture decisions in the context of multiple markets, especially where legacy brands had to navigate localization, market expansion, repositioning, or portfolio harmonization. Articles focused solely on single-market branding or new-to-market brand launches without architectural framing were excluded.

A total of 1,385 records were identified. After removal of duplicates, 1,112 unique records were screened by title and abstract. Two independent reviewers assessed eligibility, resolving conflicts through discussion. After full-text screening, 78 studies and reports met the inclusion criteria. Data extraction was performed using a standardized form capturing publication year, type of brand architecture (e.g., branded house, house of brands, hybrid), geographic scope, strategic approach (e.g., endorsement, migration, line extension), and outcome measures such as brand equity retention, consumer preference adaptation, cost efficiency, and regulatory impact. The Mixed Methods Appraisal Tool (MMAT) was used to assess methodological quality across diverse study designs.

Narrative synthesis was employed due to heterogeneity in methods and outcome metrics. Findings were grouped into five thematic domains: governance structures for cross-market brand coherence; models of portfolio simplification and SKU rationalization; localization vs standardization trade-offs; transition management for repositioning legacy brands; and regulatory, cultural, and operational barriers. Common frameworks such as the brand relationship spectrum and architecture migration pathways (e.g., phased rebranding, endorsement strategies) were frequently referenced. Insights were also drawn from empirical analysis of multinational FMCG companies across food, beverage, hygiene, and personal care sectors, particularly in Africa, Asia-Pacific, and Latin America.

Key enablers identified included the use of global brand councils, brand equity tracking across regions, modular design of packaging and communication assets, and data-driven decision-making for architecture restructuring. Limitations of the reviewed literature included varying definitions of success, inconsistent metrics across geographies, and limited longitudinal data on consumer response to brand architecture shifts. Additionally, few studies explicitly addressed legacy brands in emerging or culturally heterogeneous markets.

This review provides an evidence-based foundation for a cross-market strategy framework for legacy FMCG brand architecture, balancing consistency, adaptability, and operational viability. Future research should focus on dynamic architecture models, the impact of digital ecosystems on cross-market branding, and the role of ESG and local authenticity in shaping the next generation of brand architecture decisions.

2.1 The Role of Brand Architecture in Legacy FMCG Portfolios

Brand architecture serves as a strategic framework for organizing and managing a company's portfolio of brands, sub-brands, and products. In the context of legacy Fast-Moving Consumer Goods (FMCG) portfolios, brand architecture plays a critical role in balancing historical equity, market fragmentation, and the need for agility (Onifade *et al.*, 2021; ODETUNDE *et al.*, 2021). As legacy FMCG firms often operate across multiple markets with diverse consumer bases, regulatory landscapes, and cultural contexts, establishing a coherent yet flexible brand structure becomes essential for maintaining competitiveness and operational efficiency.

There are three primary types of brand architecture models: branded house, house of brands, and hybrid. In a branded house model, such as used by *Colgate* or *Nestlé*, the master brand is the dominant identity across product lines, leveraging centralized equity and recognition. This model offers significant advantages in terms of marketing efficiency and consistency but may struggle when addressing diverse product categories or market-specific needs. In contrast, a house of brands—exemplified by *Procter & Gamble*—consists of independent brands, each with its own positioning and identity. This allows for fine-tuned market targeting and segmentation but can lead to higher operational costs and diluted master brand equity. The hybrid model combines elements of both, where a corporate endorsement may coexist with distinct product or category brands, as seen in *Unilever's* "endorsed brands" approach (e.g., *Dove* by *Unilever*).

In legacy FMCG portfolios, which often include decades-old products, multiple acquisitions, and market-specific innovations, brand architecture becomes indispensable in managing sub-brands, stock keeping units (SKUs), and regional variants. Over time, many portfolios accumulate brand clutter—redundant or overlapping brands that confuse consumers and fragment internal resources. For example, a laundry detergent brand might exist under different names, formulations, or package designs across three regions due

to historical distributor arrangements or regulatory adaptations. Without a clear architectural system, these inconsistencies hinder brand equity consolidation and reduce marketing synergies.

Moreover, the legacy nature of many FMCG portfolios means that some sub-brands carry strong regional equities, cultural associations, or heritage values. Rationalizing or integrating these into a cohesive architecture requires nuanced decision-making to avoid alienating loyal consumer bases. This is where the architecture model chosen must be strategically aligned with portfolio realities—whether to consolidate under a single master brand for economies of scale or maintain local sub-brands for cultural relevance (ODETUNDE *et al.*, 2021; SHARMA *et al.*, 2021).

A robust brand architecture also supports global brand equity by providing a consistent expression of values, personality, and promise across markets. This consistency is crucial in an era where consumers engage with brands through borderless digital platforms, expect coherent narratives, and value trust and authenticity. However, achieving this coherence must not come at the expense of local nuance. In diverse markets, especially in emerging regions like Africa or Southeast Asia, cultural preferences, linguistic differences, and regulatory frameworks necessitate adaptation. For example, the same oral care brand may require halal certification in one market and fluoride-free formulation in another—requiring not just product differentiation but also branding flexibility.

This interplay between global consistency and local adaptability underscores the strategic tension that brand architecture must resolve. Central to this is the creation of clear brand roles, governance systems, and design principles that provide a blueprint for how the brand manifests in different contexts. Design systems and digital asset management tools can enable this duality, allowing core brand elements to remain fixed while localizable components remain flexible.

Brand architecture in legacy FMCG portfolios is far more than a structural exercise; it is a strategic tool that enables companies to manage complexity, protect and grow brand equity, and respond dynamically to evolving market conditions. Whether through a branded house, house of brands, or hybrid model, the key lies in crafting a system that balances global coherence with local authenticity—ensuring both operational efficiency and consumer resonance in an increasingly interconnected and competitive world (Onifade *et al.*, 2021; Ogeawuchi *et al.*, 2021).

2.2 Market Archetyping and Portfolio Mapping

In today's increasingly fragmented and regulated global landscape, multinational fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) companies face mounting pressure to streamline legacy brand portfolios while remaining locally relevant and operationally efficient. Market archetyping and portfolio mapping are essential strategic tools that enable these organizations to navigate the complexities of international branding as shown in figure 1(Olajide *et al.*, 2021; Ojika *et al.*, 2021). By segmenting markets according to structural and behavioral variables—such as regulatory intensity, consumer sophistication, and cultural variance—companies can better assign brand roles, manage positioning, and optimize their portfolios to eliminate redundancy and underperformance.

Effective market archetyping begins with the classification of operating environments using multi-dimensional segmentation. Four critical dimensions include market maturity, regulatory stringency,

consumer sophistication, and cultural variance. Each of these axes informs the strategic latitude available for brand architecture and portfolio deployment.

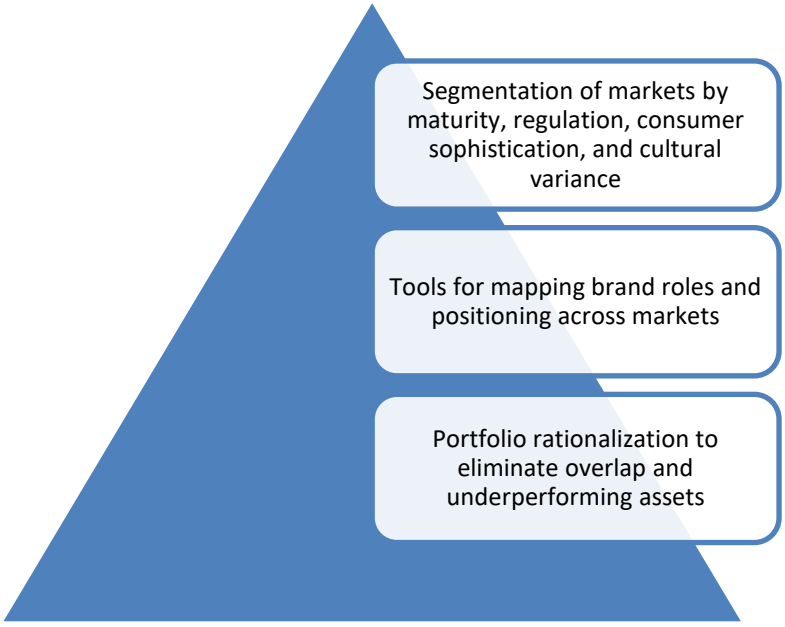

Figure 1: Market Archetyping and Portfolio Mapping

Market maturity refers to the stage of economic development and category penetration in a given region. Mature markets, such as Western Europe or North America, often have saturated categories, well-established brand hierarchies, and price-driven competition. In contrast, emerging markets may present growth opportunities, especially for legacy brands with accessible price points and heritage equity. Portfolio decisions in mature markets typically favor consolidation and innovation-driven differentiation, while in developing markets, expansion and awareness-building may be prioritized (Daraojimba *et al.*, 2022; Olajide *et al.*, 2022).

Regulatory environments differ vastly by geography. Some markets enforce strict guidelines on advertising, product labeling, or flavor descriptors—particularly in categories like food, beverages, tobacco alternatives, or personal care. High-regulation markets may necessitate product reformulations, compliant sub-brands, or unbranded packaging strategies. Conversely, low-regulation markets offer more leeway for masterbrand promotion, flavor innovation, and cross-category extensions. Brand architecture in such contexts must balance regulatory compliance with agility and scalability (Daraojimba *et al.*, 2021; Ojika *et al.*, 2021).

Consumer sophistication shapes how brands are perceived, evaluated, and selected. In highly sophisticated markets, consumers may seek transparency, functional claims, or ESG-aligned values. In lower-sophistication markets, brand trust, affordability, and familiarity often dominate purchasing behavior. The brand communication style, complexity of value proposition, and use of sub-brands should be adapted accordingly.

Cultural variance captures localized taste preferences, language nuances, religious beliefs, and social taboos that impact brand acceptance. For example, a hygiene brand's messaging in Southeast Asia may emphasize community well-being and ritual purity, while the same brand in Latin America may adopt a family-oriented, aspirational tone (Ojika *et al.*, 2022; Olajide *et al.*, 2022). These cultural inflections must guide the deployment of brand formats—whether global masterbrands, regional variants, or local legacy brands.

Once markets are segmented into archetypes, companies must map the roles of individual brands within their portfolios. Tools such as the *Brand Relationship Spectrum* (ranging from branded house to house of brands) and the *Strategic Brand Role Matrix* (flagship, support, incubator, transitional, or sunset brands) assist in organizing brand presence across territories. These frameworks enable organizations to determine whether a brand should serve as a masterbrand, be endorsed by a global parent, or operate independently due to strong local equity (Owobu *et al.*, 2021; Otokiti *et al.*, 2021).

Geo-portfolio mapping overlays brand roles onto market archetypes to identify deployment strategies. For instance, a masterbrand may dominate in standardized, low-regulation environments but require sub-branding or localization in culturally divergent or high-regulation markets. Visualization tools—such as multi-layered brand maps or heatmaps of performance by market—can help decision-makers understand the global footprint, assess overlaps, and identify white spaces for innovation or acquisition (Olajide *et al.*, 2022; Otokiti *et al.*, 2022).

Additionally, portfolio mapping requires the integration of business intelligence data, including brand equity scores, profitability by SKU, cannibalization rates, and consumer retention metrics. Decision matrices that combine internal performance data with external market archetypes provide a structured basis for brand migration strategies, such as moving from standalone legacy brands to global endorsements or retiring overlapping assets.

Portfolio rationalization is a logical extension of mapping, aimed at streamlining brand assets while preserving or enhancing consumer impact. Legacy FMCG firms often carry brand clutter—resulting from past mergers, market-specific launches, or lack of strategic coherence—that dilutes marketing spend, confuses consumers, and adds supply chain complexity. Rationalization involves both the elimination of redundant brands and the pruning of underperforming SKUs within surviving brand families.

One effective method is the *SKU productivity index*, which compares contribution margin and velocity against consumer reach within each archetyped market. Brands or variants falling below predefined thresholds, especially when duplicated by similar offerings, become candidates for delisting (Olajide *et al.*, 2022; Ibidunni *et al.*, 2022). This process also considers channel-specific performance (e.g., modern trade vs informal retail), seasonality, and cannibalization of flagship products.

Rationalization must also account for *strategic value*, such as whether a sub-brand acts as a regulatory workaround, a testing platform for new propositions, or a gatekeeper in a competitor-dominated region. Brands with symbolic or institutional equity may warrant retention despite modest performance, particularly in markets where consumer loyalty is deeply embedded in cultural identity (Alonge *et al.*, 2021; Otokiti *et al.*, 2021).

Market archetyping and portfolio mapping provide essential capabilities for managing legacy FMCG brand architectures across diverse, dynamic markets. By segmenting regions according to maturity, regulation, sophistication, and cultural diversity, and applying structured tools to assign brand roles, firms can align global consistency with local relevance. Portfolio rationalization enables companies to reduce complexity, sharpen focus, and reallocate resources toward high-potential assets. In an era where agility, compliance, and efficiency are key, these strategies offer a roadmap for revitalizing legacy brand portfolios and building future-proof cross-market brand architectures (Alonge *et al.*, 2021; Owobu *et al.*, 2021).

2.3 Strategic Harmonization vs. Local Differentiation

In managing legacy Fast-Moving Consumer Goods (FMCG) portfolios across diverse markets, companies face the central challenge of balancing strategic harmonization with local differentiation. This tension is particularly critical for brands that have accumulated extensive sub-brands, regional variants, and localized communications over time. An effective brand architecture must support global coherence while enabling local relevance, especially in increasingly fragmented regulatory and cultural environments (Halliday, 2021; Nwabekee *et al.*, 2021).

A key starting point in navigating this balance is determining which brand equities should be maintained globally and which should adapt to local market realities. Global equities include foundational elements such as brand name, core values, visual identity, and master brand messaging. These elements anchor brand consistency, enhance recognition across markets, and leverage scale in global campaigns. For instance, Coca-Cola's red-and-white color scheme, dynamic ribbon device, and universal positioning around refreshment and happiness are preserved globally, enabling efficient marketing and instant brand recall.

In contrast, local equities often involve product formats, packaging, claims, flavor variants, and language adaptations. These components respond to region-specific consumer preferences, dietary norms, regulatory requirements, and cultural values (Olajide *et al.*, 2022; Otokiti and Onalaja, 2022). For example, Unilever adapts the formulation and scent profile of its Dove products to suit local skin types and climate conditions, while maintaining the overarching narrative of "Real Beauty" and gentle skincare. This allows for deep local resonance without undermining the global brand essence.

To operationalize this balance, companies can employ a decision framework that classifies brand elements by their strategic function and adaptability. The framework typically distinguishes between three layers; Fixed Global Elements, these include the brand's purpose, tone of voice, core logo, and overarching promise. These should remain consistent to maintain trust and equity. Adaptable Elements, these involve tagline translation, secondary color palettes, and campaign visuals, which can be tailored for cultural and linguistic alignment while preserving intent. Localized Elements, these include product variants, ingredient disclosures, packaging formats (e.g., sachets vs. bottles), and claims tailored to regulatory standards and consumer behaviors (Nwabekee *et al.*, 2021).

This modular approach allows brands to scale efficiently while retaining market agility. Digital tools such as design systems, templated asset libraries, and localized content management platforms help implement this framework across markets, reducing time-to-market and ensuring compliance.

Coca-Cola is an exemplary case of hybrid brand architecture. While the core Coca-Cola brand maintains global consistency in identity, messaging, and visual codes, it allows for local adaptation through regional campaigns such as "Share a Coke," where names and local languages were printed on bottles. In Africa and Latin America, Coca-Cola also offers varied pack sizes and pricing models tailored to local economic conditions, without compromising its central brand narrative.

Similarly, Unilever employs a hybrid architecture across its diverse portfolio. The corporate brand endorses high-equity sub-brands like *Lifebuoy*, *Knorr*, and *Surf*, each of which operates with a degree of autonomy to address local health, dietary, or cultural needs (Olajide *et al.*, 2022; Oludare *et al.*, 2022). For instance, *Knorr*'s

recipe base in Southeast Asia highlights local spices and cooking methods, whereas its European variants emphasize low-salt and sustainability messaging. Unilever's structure enables both brand leverage and local innovation, particularly critical in volatile or regulation-sensitive markets.

Achieving the right balance between harmonization and differentiation is fundamental to the success of legacy FMCG portfolios in global markets. While harmonization offers consistency, efficiency, and global brand equity, differentiation ensures cultural relevance, regulatory compliance, and consumer connection. A structured, tiered framework—supported by digital tools and informed by local insights—enables companies to navigate this complexity effectively. By adopting hybrid architectures, brands like Coca-Cola and Unilever demonstrate that strategic flexibility, when built on a stable global foundation, is key to long-term relevance and growth across diverse markets (Adelusi *et al.*, 2022; OSAMIKA *et al.*, 2022).

2.4 Governance Mechanisms for Cross-Market Consistency

Maintaining brand consistency across diverse markets is a persistent challenge for legacy fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) companies operating globally. Cross-market governance mechanisms are essential to ensure that brand strategy, messaging, and execution remain aligned while allowing sufficient flexibility to respond to local cultural, regulatory, and consumer contexts. Effective governance structures must balance central control with local responsiveness through well-designed organizational models, robust tools, and collaborative processes that promote alignment and accountability (Ogeawuchi *et al.*, 2022; Oyeyemi, 2022).

One of the primary governance decisions concerns the degree of centralization in brand management. In centralized models, strategic decisions, brand positioning, and creative development are owned by global or regional headquarters, ensuring a unified brand voice, streamlined asset production, and efficient budget allocation. This approach is well-suited for masterbrands or standardized product categories, especially in mature or low-variance markets. However, centralized governance may limit responsiveness to market-specific consumer preferences or regulatory nuances, leading to missed opportunities for cultural relevance or compliance.

Conversely, decentralized brand management empowers local market teams to tailor brand expressions, product formats, and campaigns to local realities. This model supports agility and local resonance but can lead to fragmented brand equity, duplication of effort, and internal brand confusion if not properly coordinated. As a result, many FMCG multinationals adopt hybrid governance structures, where core brand equities are centrally defined, but implementation—such as packaging, language, and promotional tactics—is locally adapted under strict brand guidelines (Kufile *et al.*, 2022; Kisina *et al.*, 2022).

To support these structures, companies increasingly rely on standardized brand guidelines, compliance checklists, and digital asset management (DAM) platforms. Brand guidelines serve as foundational tools that codify visual identity, tone of voice, claims usage, and regulatory compliance requirements. These are essential for maintaining brand consistency across agencies, teams, and geographies. Compliance checklists, particularly those aligned with regulatory frameworks (e.g., health claims, environmental labeling), ensure that local adaptations do not compromise legal integrity or brand trust. Digital platforms centralize approved assets—such as logos, packshots, campaign materials, and POS tools—enabling controlled sharing,

localization, and version tracking. Such platforms not only reduce creative redundancy but also foster efficiency and brand cohesion (John and Oyeyemi, 2022; Oyeyemi, 2022).

Beyond tools and structures, internal alignment through cross-functional and cross-market collaboration is critical. Governance councils or brand steering committees, often composed of representatives from marketing, legal, regulatory affairs, R&D, and market leadership, provide structured oversight of brand decisions. These bodies evaluate proposed innovations, resolve localization tensions, and approve exceptions to global standards when justified by local conditions. Regular inter-market workshops, shared dashboards, and collaborative innovation sprints help harmonize perspectives and create institutional knowledge across regions (Onifade *et al.*, 2021; Olajide *et al.*, 2022).

Moreover, training and onboarding programs are instrumental in reinforcing brand governance. New market entrants, third-party distributors, and creative agencies must be educated on the company's brand architecture, strategic imperatives, and governance protocols. Periodic audits and performance reviews further support governance by monitoring compliance and enabling continuous improvement.

Governance mechanisms for cross-market brand consistency in FMCG portfolios require a delicate balance of centralized control, localized flexibility, and institutional coordination. Effective brand governance is not merely a structural choice—it is an ongoing organizational capability underpinned by digital infrastructure, shared accountability, and cross-functional dialogue. As brand portfolios expand across culturally and legally diverse environments, such governance becomes indispensable to sustaining brand equity, operational efficiency, and consumer trust on a global scale (Onibokun *et al.*, 2022; Abayomi *et al.*, 2022).

2.5 Measurement and Strategic ROI

In managing cross-market brand architecture for legacy Fast-Moving Consumer Goods (FMCG) portfolios, measurement and strategic return on investment (ROI) are essential for evaluating the efficacy and value creation of harmonization and localization strategies. As FMCG companies increasingly align brand portfolios across global and regional markets, they must apply robust metrics and tracking tools to assess the impact on brand equity, operational efficiency, and market performance (Ogeawuchi *et al.*, 2022; Agboola *et al.*, 2022). The measurement framework must capture not only financial returns but also strategic outcomes such as brand coherence, consumer relevance, and regulatory resilience.

Key performance indicators (KPIs) for evaluating cross-market brand architecture effectiveness span multiple domains. First, brand equity metrics—including brand awareness, preference, purchase intent, and net promoter score (NPS)—offer insights into how consistently the brand is perceived and valued across markets. Harmonized branding efforts aim to amplify these indicators by ensuring a unified narrative and identity, especially in digital and cross-border platforms. Second, SKU productivity serves as a critical metric to assess the profitability and strategic fit of individual products within the broader portfolio (Olajide *et al.*, 2022). SKU rationalization—a common outcome of brand architecture alignment—can reduce redundancy, streamline production, and improve shelf efficiency. Metrics such as revenue per SKU, margin contribution, and sales velocity can guide decisions about which product variants to retain, consolidate, or eliminate.

Another important KPI is speed-to-market, particularly for new product introductions and packaging adaptations. A standardized brand architecture, supported by modular design systems and digital asset libraries, can significantly reduce development and launch cycles. Measuring time from concept approval to

in-market execution provides a quantitative basis to evaluate process improvements resulting from architectural harmonization (Olajide *et al.*, 2022).

To ensure consistency and relevance, FMCG companies must also deploy tools to track brand coherence and consumer perception across geographies. These include global brand trackers, social listening dashboards, and consumer sentiment analytics, which can detect shifts in brand alignment or misinterpretations caused by cultural or linguistic nuances. Surveys and focus groups—particularly in markets undergoing architecture transitions—can surface early signals of brand dilution or confusion, allowing companies to course-correct (Fagbore *et al.*, 2022; Abayomi *et al.*, 2022). Advanced methods like semiotics analysis, eye-tracking for packaging consistency, and conjoint studies for attribute prioritization are increasingly used to assess whether standardized brand elements (e.g., logos, color codes, messaging) are being interpreted uniformly across cultures.

Beyond operational and perception metrics, it is essential to develop ROI models that evaluate the strategic return on harmonization investments. These models should compare the cost of restructuring brand architecture (including asset redesign, internal training, and marketing re-launches) with quantifiable benefits over time. Benefits may include reduced creative and production costs, enhanced media buying efficiency, greater supply chain flexibility, and improved consumer retention due to a more consistent brand experience. Techniques such as marketing mix modeling (MMM) and multi-touch attribution can help isolate the contribution of brand coherence to revenue uplift and cost savings.

Moreover, scenario analysis and benchmarking are valuable tools in strategic ROI assessment. For instance, companies can simulate the financial outcomes of different architecture models (e.g., maintaining regional sub-brands vs. transitioning to a master brand) over a multi-year horizon, considering market volatility, consumer trends, and regulatory scenarios. Comparing these projections against industry peers who have undertaken similar transformations—such as Unilever's transition to unified sustainability messaging or Coca-Cola's shift to a masterbrand architecture—can contextualize performance expectations and guide investment decisions (Olajide *et al.*, 2022).

The measurement of cross-market brand architecture is multi-dimensional, encompassing performance, perception, and efficiency. A comprehensive KPI framework, supported by real-time analytics tools and ROI modeling, allows FMCG companies to make informed decisions on brand architecture investments. As legacy portfolios evolve in response to global integration pressures and local demands, measurement will continue to play a pivotal role in ensuring that brand architecture delivers both immediate value and long-term strategic advantage (Akpe *et al.*, 2022; Fagbore *et al.*, 2022).

2.6 Adaptability and Future-Proofing

In the evolving landscape of fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG), adaptability and future-proofing have become essential pillars for sustaining brand relevance and operational resilience. As consumer preferences, regulatory environments, and technological capabilities shift rapidly, legacy brand architectures must evolve beyond static constructs. They must be dynamic systems—modular, data-driven, and digitally enabled—capable of accommodating market discontinuities, product diversification, and cross-market complexity as

shown in figure 2. Future-proofing brand architecture is not only a strategic imperative but a practical response to volatility and innovation in global FMCG sectors.

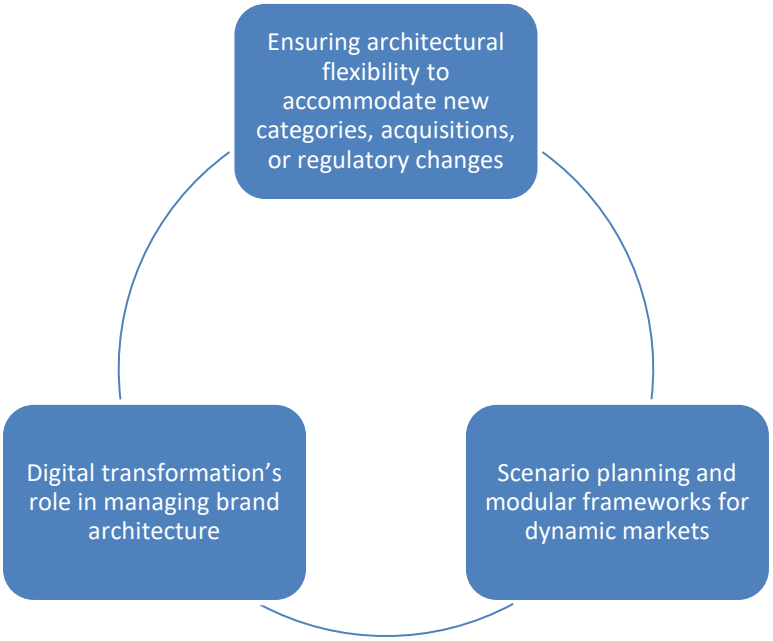

Figure 2: Adaptability and Future-Proofing

One of the core enablers of adaptability is architectural flexibility. Legacy portfolios, often burdened with redundant sub-brands, siloed categories, or fragmented identities, must be restructured to absorb new business developments such as category expansion, mergers, or acquisitions (Odetunde *et al.*, 2022; Ogeawuchi *et al.*, 2022). For example, when an FMCG company enters a wellness segment or acquires a plant-based snack brand, its existing brand architecture must allow for integration without eroding equity or confusing consumers. This requires frameworks that can seamlessly extend existing masterbrands, introduce endorsed sub-brands, or support stand-alone insurgent brands when needed. Flexibility also ensures rapid compliance with regulatory shifts—such as mandated descriptor changes in tobacco alternatives, labeling restrictions in food and beverage, or ingredient bans in cosmetics—without undermining brand continuity. Modular brand systems, where individual elements such as logos, claims, or color palettes can be adapted while preserving core identity, are particularly effective in meeting these demands (Olajide *et al.*, 2022).

Digital transformation is reshaping how companies manage, monitor, and optimize brand architecture across markets and platforms. Central to this transformation are digital asset management (DAM) systems, which enable global teams to access, adapt, and deploy approved branding materials efficiently and consistently. These platforms ensure rapid localization while maintaining compliance with brand standards and legal guidelines. More advanced systems now incorporate artificial intelligence (AI) to automate content tagging, flag inconsistencies, and personalize creative assets for different channels or consumer segments. For instance, AI-driven analytics platforms can monitor performance metrics (e.g., engagement rates, shelf presence, or claim recall) across regions, providing data to refine brand positioning and asset usage. Moreover, predictive analytics can identify emerging category trends, flavor preferences, or competitor moves, allowing brand teams to proactively adjust their architecture in anticipation of market shifts rather than in reaction.

Future-proofing also depends on scenario planning and modular frameworks, which allow brands to remain resilient in the face of economic, regulatory, or cultural change. Scenario planning entails developing future-state narratives—such as a tightening of regional health regulations, the rise of sustainability mandates, or the proliferation of D2C channels—and stress-testing current brand portfolios against these possibilities. Modular frameworks support this by designing brand systems where components (e.g., pack format, messaging hierarchy, value propositions) can be reconfigured with minimal disruption. This is particularly important in volatile or emerging markets, where brands must frequently pivot between formal and informal retail channels, digital and physical interfaces, or shifting consumer confidence (Nwani *et al.*, 2022; Olajide *et al.*, 2022).

The value of these approaches was demonstrated during the COVID-19 pandemic, which forced FMCG brands to rapidly shift communication channels, adjust product claims (e.g., hygiene, immunity), and manage supply chain disruptions. Companies with modular, digitized, and well-governed brand architectures were better equipped to adapt without losing strategic coherence or consumer trust.

Ultimately, adaptability and future-proofing are not one-time initiatives but continuous processes embedded in brand governance, digital operations, and strategic foresight. Legacy FMCG brands must shed rigid legacy structures in favor of dynamic systems that align global strategy with local agility. By embedding flexibility, harnessing digital tools, and preparing for multiple futures, companies can ensure that their brand architectures remain coherent, compliant, and competitive in an increasingly complex marketplace (Ojika *et al.*, 2022; Olajide *et al.*, 2022).

Conclusion

In today's increasingly fragmented and competitive global landscape, the deployment of a cross-market brand architecture framework is critical for legacy FMCG portfolios seeking sustained relevance and operational coherence. As brands expand across geographies with varied consumer preferences, regulatory landscapes, and market maturities, a structured approach to brand architecture enables companies to manage complexity without compromising consistency. By clearly delineating which brand elements should be globally harmonized and which require local adaptation, FMCG firms can maintain a cohesive brand identity while remaining culturally and legally responsive.

The strategic benefits of such a framework are manifold. First, efficiency gains emerge from streamlined design systems, SKU rationalization, and centralized asset management, reducing time-to-market and cost redundancies. Second, consumer relevance is enhanced as brand portfolios become more closely aligned with regional expectations, lifestyles, and usage contexts, enabling greater emotional resonance and purchase intent. Third, regulatory compliance is facilitated through standardized processes and localized checklists, which mitigate risk and ensure faster adaptation to shifting legal requirements—particularly crucial in high-scrutiny sectors such as food, health, and personal care.

To maintain these advantages, companies must commit to continuous architectural audits and adaptive brand governance. Regularly evaluating the strategic fit of sub-brands, visual systems, and product hierarchies ensures alignment with evolving market dynamics. Governance structures—such as brand councils, digital

asset libraries, and decision frameworks—must remain agile to accommodate innovation, acquisitions, and regulatory changes.

Ultimately, cross-market brand architecture should not be viewed as a static blueprint but as a living system—constantly informed by data, grounded in strategy, and responsive to the complexities of global FMCG ecosystems. In embracing this approach, legacy portfolios can transform fragmentation into strategic advantage, driving both growth and resilience in a rapidly evolving marketplace.

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